

Avoiding Rental Scams

Finding your new, off-campus home in New York City can be a rewarding, but sometimes stressful experience. Below are some tips to remember as you're searching to help you avoid possible scam listings and remain safe.



Be Cautious of the following

- **A space offered well below market.** If it's too good to be true, it probably is. Be mindful about moving quickly on a below market space, as it may not be what it seems.
- **A landlord who requests that you wire money.** Legitimate landlords will not ask renters to wire money to any account, especially an account located abroad. They also will not ask for money by Western Union, MoneyGram, or other money transfer service.

- **A claim of affiliation with NYU.** Scammers may attempt to impersonate this site to make it seem like we participate in the lease transaction or transfer of funds. We do not participate in any transactions between landlords and renters, and we will never ask you for money to use our site or any of our services.
- **A sketchy landlord story.** Perhaps the landlord says they must relocate and rent the unit out in the next few days. They say you can walk by the building, but no one can show it to you because everyone has already moved out. You may also need to commit by the next day because dozens of people are waiting to sign the lease. A legitimate landlord will meet you in person and allow you to tour the property before asking for a deposit to secure the rental.
- **An inability to meet the landlord in person.** The landlord/agent is unable or refuses to meet you in person and show the property. They may even send you an access code to unlock an electronic lockbox to gain entry by yourself to the space you are looking to rent.

What You Can Do

- **Request and expect an exact street address and apartment number.** You can cross reference this later with Google and Google Maps Street View.
- **Do your own research.** What type of building is it? Does it have an elevator? Look for inconsistencies in the listing and/or information you were provided.
- **If looking for a space in a luxury building, contact the building first,** as they may rent directly to tenants.
- **Avoid all-cash deals.** Ensure there is a way to document your lease and your payments to your landlord or building.

- **Be wary of subletting scams.** Ask for a copy of the tenant's current lease and create an agreement with them that includes dates, rent amount, etc.
- **Rent only spaces that you have seen in person.** Sometimes you may need to rent a space and have no way to visit it beforehand. See if a friend or colleague can visit for you and walk you through on a video call.
- **Try to visit a new space with a friend or colleague.** Touring with a buddy can be helpful when interacting with brokers or landlords.
- **Remember you can cosign a lease with a family member as guarantor,** or friend instead of paying money to a third party if your income does not meet the landlord or building requirements.

Report scams immediately

Include as much detail as possible, such as copies of the communications with the scammer and money transfer details to:

- offcampus@costar.com
- NYU Campus Safety at 212.998.2222 or via the Safe NYU app
- **The Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3)** (<https://www.ic3.gov/>)
- **The Federal Trade Commission** (<https://reportfraud.ftc.gov/#/>)
- If you sent money by Western Union or MoneyGram, those vendors' customer service departments may be able to stop the transfer:
 - **Western Union Complaint Procedure**
(<https://www.westernunion.com/us/en/legal/file-complaint.html>)

- **MoneyGram Complaint Procedure**

(<https://www.moneygram.com/mgo/us/en/help/contact/>)

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